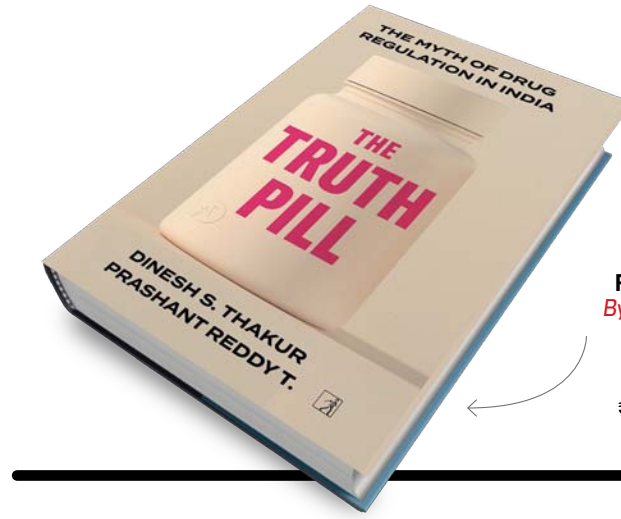
BOOKS

BITTER MEDICINE

By Gagandeep Kang



THE TRUTH PILL
The Myth of Drug Regulation in India
By Dinesh Thakur and Prashant Reddy T.
SIMON & SCHUSTER INDIA
₹899 (hardback); **508** pages

In October, the World Health Organization reported that the deaths of 66 children due to acute kidney failure in The Gambia were potentially linked to four brands of cough syrups manufactured by Maiden Pharmaceuticals in Haryana. The deaths took place over a few months and a WHO laboratory analysis following investigations in September found unacceptable amounts of diethylene glycol and ethylene glycol in the products. A medical alert was issued after informing the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation on September 29. An inspection of the manufacturing facility found lapses and production was halted. Many statements were made on whether it was central or state responsibility to permit manufacture and/ or export, and the WHO process questioned. Within a few weeks, the news was no longer on the front pages.

Dinesh Thakur and Prashant Reddy's exploration of the regulatory system in India starts with a near-identical story—of children in Jammu dying because of a syrup contaminated with diethylene glycol, the fifth such mass poisoning incident in India. Thakur is well-known as the whistle-blower in the Ranbaxy case, a story told in Katherine Eban's *Bottle of Lies*. Reddy is a lawyer, who with the help of students and colleagues framed Right to Information (RTI) applications and waded through publicly available documents to sketch a history of drug regulation in India, its implementation and consequences.

Of all the nations in the world, India has the longest written Constitution. But, as the book points out, there is a large gap between structures and processes prescribed for governance, and actual governing to provide citizens access to quality medication. The federal structure of the government, which enables division of powers, also results in a disconnect that hampers implementation. Often, it is also deployed to avoid making changes that could allow investigation of poor processes and fraud. The Centre-state separation also leads to RTIs and accountability entering an infinite loop with statements that no records exist in that location and consequent transfer between officials. The authors use their experience of filing RTIs to highlight the poor regulatory design that lets pharma companies get away with producing sub-standard drugs. They also point to the risible punishments courts impose, discounting the value of health and lives.

INDIA REMAINS THE PHARMACY OF THE THE WORLD BUT HAS A LONG WAY TO GO IN DRUG REGULATION

The authors pay special attention to Ayurveda and traditional medicine, describing the long history of non-western medicine being treated as a special category, not subject to the rigour of standardised manufacture or evaluation of claims of efficacy. Frequently, these drugs are found to have high heavy metal content and steroids that can cause serious, long-term harm.

Overall, this is a well-structured, well-researched book that highlights issues that are not common knowledge. Each chapter is backed with extensive bibliography. The first two chapters, describing the history of drug regulation in the world and in pre-Independence India, form an excellent background for the chapters that follow. However, coming in at over 500 pages, one would have expected all aspects of regulation in India to have been covered, but blood products or blood banking, vaccines or devices, which include implantable devices like stents and artificial joints, have not been addressed.

India is the pharmacy of the world, providing generics globally, including to highly regulated markets. The fact that Indian companies can and do provide these drugs and they are accepted indicates that the capacity exists for high-quality manufacturing of pharmaceuticals. But the frequent instances of drugs failing quality tests in India and outside, and the less frequent but very serious issue of drugs made in India harming patients, indicates that we have a long way to go with our regulatory processes. The authors refer to the several attempts made to improve regulation and how every attempt has been thwarted. Interestingly, they also describe the iterations of published rules and statements by regulators to suggest that the intention of revisions is to facilitate the pharmaceutical industry. This approach of facilitating industry without necessary oversight can have serious consequences for the public, as revealed in the many stories throughout the book.

The role of a regulator is to ensure that products intended for use are of high quality, safe and efficacious. Thakur and Reddy have used their research to give us a must-read account of how long a road we still have to travel. ■

The reviewer teaches at CMC Vellore